

24.1 INTRODUCTION

As a professional, you may face countless situations in which it is essential for you to prepare technical documents. These could range from reports, notices, letters, and memos to proposals. In the preceding chapters, we have dealt with all other elements except proposals. So now let us discuss what a proposal is, its features, structure, and style in this chapter.

When a company thinks of a merger with another company, it may ask its personnel to submit a proposal reviewing the possible industrial and commercial developments that might make the merger desirable. If some multimedia laboratory wishes to approach various colleges and universities for setting up multimedia lab, they are required to understand the needs of the specific organization and submit a proposal based on their requirement. Thus, a *technical proposal* is a written offer from a person who has a selling idea to a prospective buyer. It intends to elicit business from a prospective buyer. Proposals have important place in business growth and professional relationships. The cut-throat competition in global business has made it essential for companies to look for new ideas to sustain their market and growth. Often, it is confused with *business plan*. However, a business plan is different from a *business proposal*. A business plan is usually drafted to get capital for the start-up venture. These plans cover your business structure, your products and services, your market research and marketing strategy, and your complete budget and financial projections. A technical or business proposal however is written by some professional or expert who proposes to sort out a technical, business, or managerial proposal of a prospective buyer. A proposal also identifies the prospective buyer's need to implement new ideas for enhancing efficiency, increasing productivity, and improving performance in various professional operations.

Before we talk about the features, structure, and style of a proposal, let us understand the differences between a report (read in Chapter 23), a proposal, and a business plan. Though they are similar to some extent, there exist various differences between them which are worth noting (Table 24.1).

Table 24.1 Differences between a Report, a Proposal, and a Business Plan

Proposal	Report	Business Plan
It is written to someone who needs to sort out a technical, management, or business problem or needs to implement new ideas to enhance efficiency and productivity in various professional operations.	Written to someone with authority to know the causes of the problem and possibly take a decision.	It is written to someone who needs to make a decision for profit making or strengthening its operational aspects.
It identifies a particular need, explains it thoroughly, and recommends how this need can best be met.	Written to identify a specific problem, explain it, and recommend action that will lead to a solution.	Like proposals, it identifies the workable idea, explains all aspects related to financial needs, target market, demographics and other information.
Formal but persuasive style.	Formal in style.	Persuasive.
It involves cost for the execution of proposed idea.	It only highlights the reasons based on the interpretation of data and make recommendations.	It is written to get capital for a start-up venture.
It is written to someone whose decision will directly benefit the writer in some way.	It is written to people who can take action or affect outcome.	Both the applicant and the approving authority aim at making profit.
It also deals with future professional possibilities. Since it is often put forth by experts and experienced professionals, there are less chances of failure.	It deals with some event or situation that occurred in the past.	Like proposals, it deals with future action but there are chances of failure as taken up by budding entrepreneurs.

24.2 PURPOSE

As defined in the preceding section, whenever a new idea or workable solution for a problem or advice is proposed, it is called a proposal. However, in your professional life you will come across various nomenclatures which describe the purpose for which that proposal is written. Some of these are given below for your clear understanding:

1. When the aim of the proposal is to modify or create something that requires a good understanding of technical knowledge and skills, it is called a *technical proposal*.
2. A *business proposal* is a document that you submit to your company or another enterprise proposing a business arrangement dealing with any aspect of business, commerce.

or industry. These proposals help to appraise and improve the existing products and services to meet the ever changing demands of market. Sometimes these are also termed as *sales proposals* when they focus only on increasing the sales of a product or service of a company.

3. When we intend to undertake a systematic research, we are required to submit a proposal outlining broadly the basis of the proposed research, its purpose, scope, significance, limitations, etc. Such proposals also include a reference to the procedures, methods, and theories to be followed in conducting the research. Academic in nature and written with scientific objectivity, such proposals are known as *research proposals*.

24.3 IMPORTANCE

In this section, we will learn about the importance of technical proposals.

1. Proposals serve as an indicator of the growth or progress of a company or organization.
2. These proposals help to invite other companies or industries for strategic alliances, joint ventures, acquisitions, and mergers.
3. If your proposal presents your business ideas effectively, it may help the company improve its products and services to have the competitive edge.
4. By sorting out a technical problem, proposals enhance productivity and improve performance.
5. Proposals help in securing technology partnership, fundraising, donation, event sponsorship, tenders, or inviting others for participating in an event.
6. Successful proposals usually ensure financial gains too for companies.
7. Research proposals help in creating new methods and procedures, and opening new dimensions of concepts which in turn expands the horizon of knowledge.

24.4 TYPES

There are two main categories of proposals:

- Solicited (invited)
- Unsolicited (uninvited)

Whenever a proposal is drafted in response to an advertisement or demand from an authority in a company or organization or outside the organization or agency, it is termed as a *solicited proposal*. These are invited proposals. For example, when the government and large corporations wish to purchase services or products for constructing dams, bridges, providing parking facility, etc., a large number of proposals bidding for the deal are received. In such a scenario, we are left competing with all other bidders that noticed the opportunity and responded. In this case, a proposal that finally gets picked up from the massive lot not only has to provide the most effective solution to the problem or make the most lucrative deal, but should also have stronger arguments in staking claims for the bid than other competitors.

Usually solicited proposals are to be written in the format defined by the agencies that invite such offers.

In comparison, unsolicited proposals are more demanding and require greater imagination on the part of the bidder. In an *unsolicited proposal*—a non-invited proposal, we might have an idea for a product or service that would be of benefit to a particular organization. We submit a proposal to that particular organization suggesting how we can provide some service

or develop a product in exchange for funding or some other consideration. In this case, we do not know if the company is open to our proposal or not. There is every possibility that the company may not like our proposed idea. In this situation, a person may submit a proposal on his/her own initiative. Here your proposal has to convince the client that not only is the service/product potentially valuable to them, but you and your company are reliable and stable.

Whether invited or uninvited, our proposal must be well researched, well written, and must contain a properly worked out realistic budget.

24.5 STRUCTURE

Like reports, proposals too are written in a conventional or usable form. In case of solicited proposals, the structure is determined by the person or the company asking for it. In unsolicited proposals you can use the conventional sequence of element and if any other element or information is required, you have the freedom to put it forth at the right place. Since proposals are written for different purposes and for different organizations, there is no single format that suits all. According to the requirement and the nature of the proposal, you have to choose the elements to be included in the unsolicited proposals. The three main parts of a formal full length proposal are as follows (Fig. 24.1):

- Prefatory
- Main body
- Supplementary parts

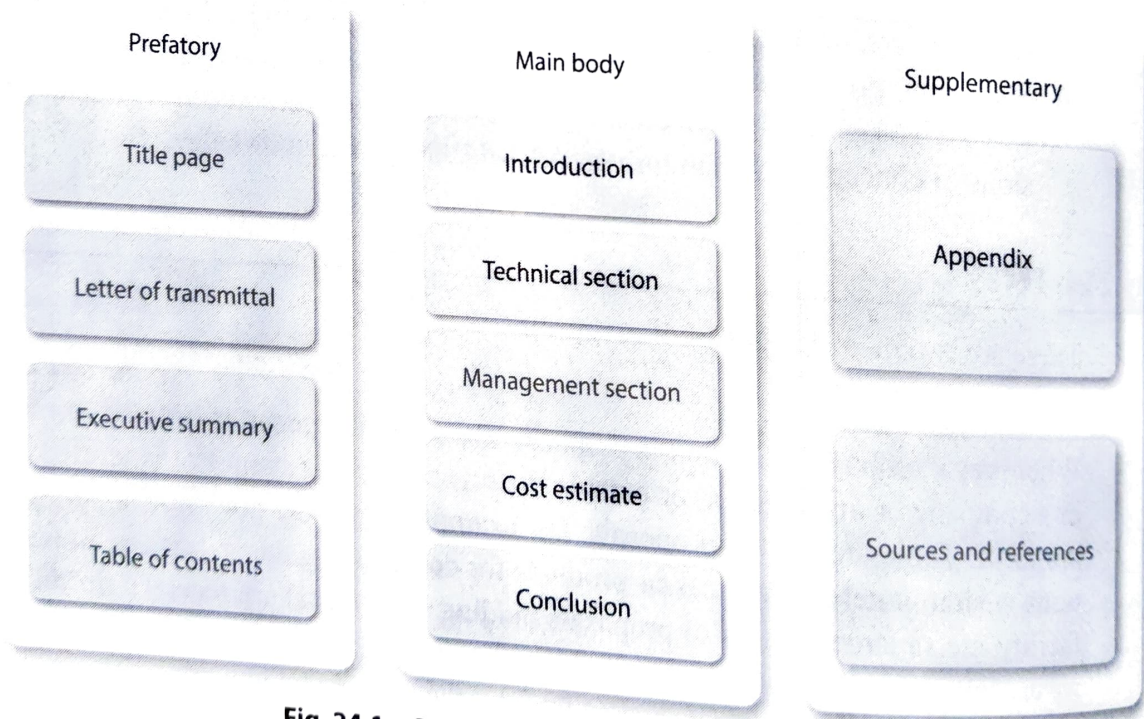


Fig. 24.1 Sections of a Formal Full Length Proposal

Title page The *title page* of a proposal serves as a cover and if laid out well with proper spacing in between the various elements of information, it creates a good impact on the reader. The title page consists of information such as the title of the proposal, the name of the organization for which it has been prepared, the proposer's name and designation, the name of the organization to which he/she belongs, and the month and year when the proposal is being submitted. Look at the following sample:

Sample Title Page

**A Proposal
on
Setting up a Recreation Community Centre at Yumiko Telecom Ltd**

Submitted to
General Manager
Yumiko Telecom Ltd, New Delhi

by
Project Manager
Salina Builders, Mumbai
Salina Builders, Mumbai

March 2015

Letter of transmittal As the title of this element suggests, a *letter of transmittal* transmits the proposal to the primary recipient. It reveals the topic, the purpose, its highlights and makes an appeal towards a favourable response. Like in case of reports, the letter of transmittal can be either sent along with the proposal or it can be bound immediately after the title page.

Table of contents In lengthy proposals (more than 10 pages) for quick location of major elements, the table of contents is given immediately after the draft contract. It is prepared the way the table of contents is prepared for a report, as discussed in Chapter 23. Short proposals do not include this element. Similarly, if there are too many illustrations, we need to give a separate list of illustrations; otherwise it is not required.

Executive summary The recipient of the proposal goes through the executive summary very carefully. He/she tries to assess whether the proposal is worth considering. The obvious reason is that it not only provides a brief background, purpose, scope, and methodology, but also gives a budget summary besides re-emphasizing the significance of the project. A proposal may not have a table of contents but it will surely have an executive summary to give a quick view of the entire proposal. This includes the following elements:

- Background
- Technical details
- Purpose
- Significance
- Scope
- Re-emphasis
- Infrastructure facilities

Let us look at a sample executive summary for a proposal:

Sample Executive Summary

Today's world, rightly known as 'The Computer Age', has taken a huge leap in the field of computers and information technology (IT). Earlier the task which used to take hours can now be done in a few minutes with the help of computers. It won't be wrong to say that today, software runs the world. Since computer technology has revolutionized our world, there is hardly any sphere of professional endeavour, including the hotel industry, that can hope to achieve a smooth and consistent growth.

Background

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We are aware of the fact that your Food Pride Internationals (FPI) is one of the most prestigious low-cost chain of hotels in India. Over the years, FPI has carved a niche for itself for the quality of food offered. However, the great customer rush has created a demand for more efficient and prompt delivery and service methods. Moreover, with the newer technological advancements, it makes a sound business strategy to utilize these advancements for efficient functioning of the organization, for a positive and emphatic impression on the clientele and for maintaining in future too the high standards of quality and operations set in the past. With the help of the software tools offered in the proposal, we propose to make the functioning of your popular chain hotels smooth and more customer friendly.

Infrastructural facilities

This proposal aims at providing high quality software tools and very efficient maintenance personnel to your chain of hotels. The services offered include installing the software tools, ensuring that the software is functioning perfectly well, and deputing competent personnel for any future troubleshooting purposes. However, the proposal does not include providing the platforms which will be required for proper functioning of our software tools. These platforms (authorized versions of Microsoft Windows XP with specific memory requirements) will have to be bought by you.

Technical overview

The computers with the above-mentioned specifications will be used by our company to install the software tools. Our team will contact you to get the specific minute requirements of the software you want to have from us. This team will stay for some time in your hotel for this purpose.

The technical standards and strength of the project emanate from the world-class hotel management software tools that we plan to use for this project. Moreover, as per your requirements, all the requisite changes will be made to make the software amenable to your system. With the installation of the software, any customer can login to the hotel website and book any room as per the availability. The website created, will be certainly user-friendly so that a customer who knows only a little about computers can also use the system. The software will also be user-friendly from the perspective of your hotel staff. Further, proper training will be provided to your staff; the training would orient your operating staff to the functioning of the software without any additional charges. Even after the entire software tool has been deployed and training is imparted to your staff, you will have 24 x 7 assistance from our side. Our technical experts will always be there to help you use the software in the best possible manner.

Significance

By adopting the proposed software, your chain of hotels will be equipped with the world-class, customer-friendly, and round-the-clock services. All this will be made available to you at a lower cost compared to other in-line companies.

Introduction Since an emphatic statement of purpose and a clear understanding of the problem are the most important aspects of your proposal, an introduction to the proposal should specify what your project intends to do. Also provide a brief review of the background information that gives rise to the present need. This helps the reader understand what needs to be done. If you fail to do so in the first paragraph of the introduction, all the efforts made in writing a

proposal will go in vain. Let us look at the following examples and understand how a catchy beginning can ensure the attention of a prospective buyer:

1. As you read through this, you are sure to understand how to improve the efficiency of the bio-metric system installed in your organization.
2. Have you ever wondered how to ensure the full safety of the lab equipment in your institute? If yes, the following pages suggest an efficient way to achieve this objective.
3. This proposal is submitted with a view to introduce to you a proven scheme for reduction of production cost by almost 10 per cent in your plant.
4. The objective of this proposal is to help you make the cars manufactured by you more efficient in terms of fuel consumption and environment protection.

In fact, the beginning of a proposal is likely to be similar to that of a sales letter as in both these types of communication, we need to capture the attention of the reader. It is particularly so in case of unsolicited proposals which catch professionals unawares and are to be read by the prospective buyers without any apparent desire or willingness to do so. In order to keep the readers interested in your proposal, try starting on an innovative note by using strategies used for drafting sales letter. Though these have been discussed in the chapter on *business letters* in detail, here is a quick reminder of the tips that can render a beginning catchy, tempting, and effective:

1. Start on a striking statement.
2. Write a short, crisp sentence.
3. Address the need of the reader rather than the desire of the author.
4. Remind the prospective buyer of the difficulties he/she faces.
5. Bring into picture the utility of the proposed idea in the reader's world.
6. Instantly build a rapport with the prospective client with a 'you' type of approach.

Having made a captivating beginning, we can make further inroads into the reader's defence by outlining the purpose and scope of the proposal. A write-up that starts intriguingly well but fails to give a clear view of the objective, purpose, scope, utility, and benefits of the proposed idea, offends the reader. Therefore, after a good start, a proposal should be able to sustain the interest of the reader.

One sure way of keeping the prospective client hooked to the proposal is to help him/her understand and appreciate the utility of the offer. Though the details of the features of the proposed idea, research, method, plan, or scheme need to be highlighted separately, it is in the introduction that the need should be established. At times, it is also required to help the reader appreciate and comprehend the problem he/she faces before recommending the solution. Therefore, begin with a clear and empathetic understanding of the prospective buyer's need; bring in the utility of the proposed solution; sustain his/her interest by highlighting its special features such as low cost, high returns, improved services, substantial experience, and established expertise and goodwill.

Written in a persuasive manner, the introductory section of a proposal should be able to capture the interest of the reader; establish the need for the proposal; bring into view the positive highlights of the proposed solution; give a clear view of the technical, monetary, and human assistance required for the successful implementation of the idea within a specified amount of time.

Technical section In writing the technical section of a proposal, provide a solution which requires a technical plan. In this section, we need to analytically explain the technical terms, theoretical principles, and methods to be followed. This section also talks about the machines, equipment, and materials that we wish to use in carrying out the proposed task. While

specifying these, clearly mention the advantages of these in bringing out the desired outcome of the whole project. Moreover, describe in detail the procedure that you plan to use. Give arguments for each step and explain how important they are for the success of the project. Use diagrams and other visual aids to emphatically and professionally present this requirement. If you require infrastructural facilities, such as an office or laboratory space, specify what those needs will be. Thus, in technical section, you should necessarily provide the technical description, methodology, and facilities required and the technical plan of action.

Management section Once the need and efficiency of the proposed solution is established, convince the reader of your ability to deliver the goods. In the management section of the proposal, highlight the following points:

Credentials of the task force involved Most of the proposals fail to click, simply because the readers do not feel convinced about the capability of the people who propose to solve their problems. The management section of the proposal should, therefore, highlight the credentials of the people who are involved or are likely to be involved in implementing the proposed idea. For this, give reference of the academic and technical knowledge of the people involved, mention their expertise and experience in the relevant field, and highlight their achievements in the past.

Company profile A good company normally boasts of good personnel and services at its disposal. In fact, the people involved and the company they represent keep affecting each other's reputation. Talk about the efficiency of the system, policies, and implementation scheme, so as to convince the reader further about the company's ability to produce good results. A company's established profile, goodwill, and reputation undoubtedly create a very positive impact on the reader. However, even in the absence of an established reputation in the stated field, one can hope to create a positive impact on the reader. This can be done by focusing clearly on the efficiency of the people involved and the efficacy of the proposed solution that is likely to come through even in the absence of a staggering company profile.

Execution plan A good proposal should always pointedly provide a clear outline of an execution plan for a proposed idea. An efficient execution plan includes a precise work schedule—

the amount of time the proposed idea will take in its implementation; date/month of the commencement and completion of the task; date-wise/month-wise work plan; details regarding the reporting, maintenance, delivery, and payment system, etc. Moreover, a clear statement establishing an adherence to the work schedule in achieving the stated objective in the specified time helps the reader feel convinced about the workability of the proposed solution. At times, proposals already implemented and running in other organizations are also appended in the appendix section of the technical proposal. The purpose is to help the reader see that you have not only an intelligence to envisage the need for the proposed solution but also an acumen to execute and implement ideas within a limited time frame.



Don't Quote Unrealistic Cost Estimate in Your Proposals.

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Cost estimate A good proposal invariably takes into account the monetary variables that finally decide whether the proposed idea actually takes off. In fact, without a clear, precise, and detailed cost estimate, all our proposals are likely to remain confined to folded files. It is so because unless the prospective buyer is able to figure out whether he/she can actually support the proposed plan financially, he/she fails to make a firm assessment about the viability of the proposal received. Therefore, it is important for us to give a proper cost estimate so as to help the reader evaluate and assess the viability of a proposal. The figures quoted in cost estimate at the end of the proposal should not differ from those suggested in the draft contract that usually comes in the earlier part of the proposal. At times, the cost is calculated in terms of the number of hours spent on a particular task.

The cost estimate of a proposal includes fixed expenses such as purchase of land and equipment, and recurrent expense such as raw material and transportation.

Conclusion A proposal usually ends with a realistic and detailed cost estimate, particularly when it is forwarded through a covering letter which is written in a persuasive and effective style. However, in order to end on an emphatic note, many bidders end their proposals with a conclusion. The purpose of a conclusion in a technical or business proposal is to remind the reader of the unique features of the proposed solution. At times, rather than writing a detailed conclusion, authors choose to end their proposals with a concluding line which, written in a persuasive manner, intends to induce action.

Appendix Appendix is not an integral part of every proposal. However, in order to help the reader feel convinced about the author's claims, an appendix can be appended to a proposal. Usually, an appendix entails the following material:

- The description and results of a similar technical or business proposal already successfully implemented elsewhere
- The curriculum vitae of the personnel involved in the task force outlining their credentials, expertise, and achievements in similar tasks
- Approved contracts signed with other companies
- The detailed historical background of the proposed plan
- Extensive details regarding the operating system to be used and the procedure to be followed as the proposed plan gets executed
- The requisite layouts and maps, if any, and any other material that is likely to make the proposal look more comprehensive, realistic, and tempting

Draft contract When some proposal is accepted, it is resubmitted with a *draft contract*. It gives a bird's-eye view of the most important information in the proposal. A draft contract includes the following elements:

- Title of the proposal
- Name of the proposer and designation (in case of research proposal, the name of the principal investigator and co-investigators' names and their designations)
- Name of the organization in which the project is to be carried out
- Duration of the project
- Terms and conditions
- Time required for the start of the project after approval
- Total cost to be followed by year-wise or phase-wise break-up of the total cost

Sample Proposal I

High Tech Lab India System St. No 17, Near Birla Mandir, Ludhiana, Punjab

The Principal
Bhagwati College of Education
Moga, Punjab

Dear Madam,

SUB: Proposal for installing High Tech Digital Language Lab (HTDLL)

We wish to introduce ourselves as a well established and leading manufacturer of communication equipments for schools, colleges and other educational institutes. High Tech Digital Language Lab or HTDLL, in a nutshell, is a professionally engineered, comprehensive and user friendly language learning software brought to you by us, a dynamic IT solutions provider focused on delivering cutting-edge solutions primarily for educational institutions. Our Digital Language Laboratory System helps in enhancing the communication skills of students by two-way communication and inbuilt audio and video recording facility.

We are forwarding our most competitive quote tailored to your requirements along with HTDLL product details and optimal system requirements for your immediate perusal.

Some of our more recent clients are as follows:

- IIT, Guwahati
- IMT, Ghaziabad
- Indian Army, Dehradun
- Shrinathji Institute of Technology & Engineering, Udaipur
- Biyani Girls College, Jaipur
- UV College, Ganpat University, Gujarat
- Amity International Schools, Delhi
- Institute of Computer and Communication Technology, Anand
- Shankersinh Vaghela Bapu Institute of Technology, Gandhinagar
- Truba College of Science & Technology—2 LABS, Bhopal
- Sanjay Ghodawat Institute of Technology, Kolhapur
- Chinara Public School, Alwar (Rajasthan)

Kindly visit us at www.htdll.in for a detailed review of our range of products, services and clientele/testimonials.

Should you require any further details/clarifications, it would only be our pleasure to oblige at once.

Thank you once again and we look forward to a mutually rewarding and long-term association.

Yours truly

Mohit Bhagat

Manager, Marketing

High Techno Systems (India) Pvt. Ltd Cochin, Bangalore & New Delhi Customer Care: 0484-4141 000 to 4141 099 (100 Lines)

Encl: Brochure and Technical Literature

Sample Proposal II

Oxbridge Institute of Technology and Science, Chennai
Department of Communication and Media Studies

A Proposal
For
A Three-day Workshop

27 January 2015

(Contd)

Communication Skills for Effective Teaching

Objective

The workshop aims at providing a platform for inculcating effective communication skills among teachers through an array of innovative strategies and a wide range of interesting activities. This, in turn would enhance the effectiveness of their teaching and improve the student-teacher relationship.

Day 1

9.00–10.00	Registration and inauguration
10.0–11.00	Innovative teaching—Sharing experiences
11.00–11.15	Tea Break
11.15–1.00	Understanding and using body language—Nonverbal agenda
1.00–2.00	Lunch
2.00–3.00	Preparing PowerPoint presentation
3.00–4.00	Mock presentation followed by discussion
4.00–4.15	Tea break
4.15–5.00	Communication activities

Day 2

9.00–10.00	Strategies for group discussion and mock GD
10.0–11.00	GD practice followed by performance appraisal
11.00–11.15	Tea break
11.15–1.00	Oral presentations by participants
1.00–2.00	Lunch
2.00–3.00	Emotional intelligence—Skills involved
3.00–4.00	Mock presentation followed by discussion
4.00–4.15	Tea break
4.15–5.00	Emotional Intelligence—Problems and solutions

Day 3

9.00–10.00	Viewing the recorded presentation and self assessment
10.0–11.00	Vocabulary enrichment
11.00–11.15	Tea break
11.15–1.00	Feedback and valedictory

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Cost Estimate

Participants	: 25 teachers from various schools in East Chennai
Tentative date	: 29-31 March 2015
Resource Persons	: 5
Registration Fee	: ₹600/- per head

BUDGET

Folders (40)	= ₹2000.00
Learning material	= ₹3000.00
Tea and snacks	= ₹10000.00
Certificate production	= ₹2500.00
Miscellaneous	= ₹1000.00

Total ₹25000.00

(Dr Abha Mittal)

Department of Communication and Media Studies